for children to get lost in a crowd, run away from home or be kidnapped, for the elderly or hospital patients to wander out of care facilities, or for criminals to escape from prisons. In such instances, it is vital to be able to track people to provide peace of mind to millions of caregivers, family members, parents and relevant authorities. An implanted microchip would make it significantly easier to track people within the critical time available.

No worry about losing cards. Cards are frequently used for many daily activities, such as making payments, taking public transport, gaining access to buildings or borrowing books from the library. The problem with these plastic cards is that these are easy to lose or can get stolen. With an implanted microchip there is no such fear, as it is impossible to lose or steal.

Ability to automatically control many devices. An implanted microchip brings a digital identity into the real world by providing the ability to automatically control a large number of devices and equipment. Imagine being able to start your car automatically, open the front door of your house as you approach it, switch on your favourite TV channel as you sit down on the couch, or even adjust the air-conditioner temperature.

Allowing only the registered owner to use a weapon. Many firearms dealers, such as Smith & Wesson and Browning, have developed an implant system for firearms that allows only the registered owner to fire his or her weapon. This effectively avoids dangerous situations in which a stolen weapon ends up in the wrong hands, or a weapon accidentally falls in the hands of children.

Potential problems and security risks

Some potential problems that come with microchip implants are given below.

Possible health risks. Implanted microchips do not always stay in place and may migrate to a different location, making them hard to find. This may become problematic in medical emergencies.

Some other risks include electrical hazards, adverse tissue reactions, infections, non-compatibility with medical equipment, such as MRI machines, and electro-surgical and electromagnetic interference with devices, such as defibrillators.

Privacy and consent-related issues. Council on Ethical and Judicial Affairs (CEJA) of American Medical Association published a report in 2007 alleging that RFID implanted microchips may compromise privacy, because there is no assurance that information contained in the microchips can be properly protected.

Concerns were raised regarding the potential abuse of microchips. Their adoption by governments as a compulsory identification program could lead to erosion of civil liberties, as well as identity theft if the devices are hacked.

Concerns were expressed that, for people with dementia, who could possibly benefit the most, obtaining